COLOSSIANS · STUDY 04 OF 12

Colossians 1:24–29

Christ in You, the Hope of Glory

Christ Is All — A Study of Colossians

Small Group Bible Study Series · NASB95

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① Text	② Devotional	③ Commentary	④ Self-Study Guide
Foundation	Personal preparation	Teacher / leader preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	*All group members*	*Teacher / leader*	*Small group*

⑤ *Application closes each study and draws from all sections above.*

Time guide: about 30 minutes — Devotional 4 · Commentary 15 · Discussion 8 · Application 3.

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① BIBLICAL TEXT

Colossians 1:24–29 · New American Standard Bible (NASB95)

1:24 *Now I rejoice in my sufferings for your sake, and in my flesh I do my share on behalf of His body, which is the church, in filling up what is lacking in Christ's afflictions.*

25 *Of this church I was made a minister according to the stewardship from God bestowed on me for your benefit, so that I might fully carry out the preaching of the word of God,*

26 *that is, the mystery which has been hidden from the past ages and generations, but has now been manifested to His saints,*

27 *to whom God willed to make known what is the riches of the glory of this mystery among the Gentiles, which is Christ in you, the hope of glory.*

28 *We proclaim Him, admonishing every man and teaching every man with all wisdom, so that we may present every man complete in Christ.*

29 *For this purpose also I labor, striving according to His power, which mightily works within me.*

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② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · Drawn from the outline of this study

The Secret That Changes Everything

> *“to whom God willed to make known what is the riches of the glory of this mystery among the Gentiles, which is Christ in you, the hope of glory”*
>
> *— Colossians 1:27 (NASB95)*

Everybody loves a good mystery. The false teachers in Colossae promised secrets reserved for a spiritual elite. Paul has a mystery too, but his is not locked away for the few. It is a secret God kept for ages and has now opened to all His saints: Christ in you, the hope of glory.

Think of it. The One who created all things and holds them together (1:16–17) has taken up residence in ordinary believers, Jew and Gentile alike, in one body. That is the riches of the glory of this mystery. No ladder of angels is needed, and no secret knowledge is required. He is already in you.

Paul suffered gladly to make that mystery known, and he labored with all the energy Christ supplied to bring believers to maturity. Christ in you is not only your comfort today. He is your hope of sharing His glory in the day when every believer is presented before Him.

For reflection

1. Do you live each day aware that Christ lives in you? What difference would that awareness make tomorrow morning?
2. Paul rejoiced in sufferings "for your sake." Is there a hardship you could view as service for the body of Christ?
3. Who in your life could you help move toward spiritual maturity this year?

The greatest mystery has been solved, and the answer is a Person who lives in you.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

> **The passage teaches:** Paul rejoices to suffer for the Church and serves as its steward to make known God's long-hidden mystery, "Christ in you, the hope of glory," and he labors in Christ's power, warning and teaching every believer so that he may present each one mature in Christ.

Outline

- **I. The Suffering for the Mystery (1:24)**
  - A. It Is for the Colossians
  - B. It Is Connected to the Afflictions of Christ
  - C. It Is for the Church
- **II. The Stewardship of the Mystery (1:25–26)**
  - A. Paul's Relation to the Mystery (1:25)
  - B. Paul's Revelation of the Mystery (1:26)
- **III. The Secret of the Mystery (1:27)**
  - A. God Willed to Reveal It
  - B. The Gentiles Received It
  - C. "Christ in You" Defines It
- **IV. The Success of the Mystery (1:28–29)**
  - A. The Goal: Presenting Every Believer Complete (1:28c)
  - B. The Means: Proclaiming Christ (1:28a–b)
  - C. The Method: Laboring in His Power (1:29)

Introduction

At the end of verse 23 Paul called himself a minister of the gospel. Now he explains what that ministry has meant for him. The false teachers prized mysteries and secret knowledge. Paul answers with God's mystery, once hidden and now revealed, and it is not an idea but a Person. We may outline his words under four headings: the suffering for the mystery, the stewardship of the mystery, the secret of the mystery, and the success of the mystery.

I. The Suffering for the Mystery (1:24)

A. It Is for the Colossians

"Now I rejoice in my sufferings for your sake." Paul was suffering as he wrote. He was imprisoned unjustly, and now news had come that the Colossian church was under pressure from false teachers. He had endured physical beatings, emotional strain, and "the daily pressure … of concern for all the churches" (2 Cor. 11:23–28). He counted all of it as suffering for the churches, including this one he had never visited.

B. It Is Connected to the Afflictions of Christ

"And in my flesh I do my share on behalf of His body … in filling up what is lacking in Christ's afflictions." Any believer reading these words might draw back and say, "Christ's sufferings were complete, lacking nothing!" And he would be right. Jesus said, "It is finished!" (John 19:30). His sacrifice for sin was once for all (Rom. 3:21–26; Heb. 10:10–14). Paul is not saying otherwise.

First, the word for "afflictions" here (*thlipsis*) is never used in the New Testament of Christ's atoning sufferings on the cross. The standard lexicon (BDAG) defines it as distress brought about by outward circumstances. It refers to the trials of life, not the pains of atoning death. Jesus suffered such trials, and "all who desire to live godly in Christ Jesus will be persecuted" (2 Tim. 3:12). Christ began these sufferings; they did not end with Him. His people carry them on until He returns and puts all suffering away forever.

Second, when the body suffers, the Head feels it. Jesus did not ask Saul of Tarsus, "Why are you persecuting My followers?" but "Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting **Me**?" (Acts 9:4). The afflictions of the Church are, in a real sense, the afflictions of Christ.

C. It Is for the Church

"On behalf of His body, which is the church." Paul's sufferings were not for himself alone. They served the whole body of Christ, past, present, and future. Every believer who has been strengthened by this letter is a beneficiary of Paul's chains.

II. The Stewardship of the Mystery (1:25–26)

A. Paul's Relation to the Mystery (1:25)

1. He is a minister of it

"Of this church I was made a minister according to the stewardship from God bestowed on me for your benefit." The word "minister" (*diakonos*) means servant. Paul serves the church "according to" a stewardship (*oikonomia*), a household management entrusted to him by God. A steward does not own what he manages; he dispenses it faithfully for the Master. Paul's stewardship was given "for your benefit," for the Colossians and for all the Gentiles.

2. He is a teacher of it

"So that I might fully carry out the preaching of the word of God." To fulfill the Word, Paul had to teach the Word. He could not simply stand up and say, "This is what you must believe and do." He had to deliver it, explain it, and apply it until the full counsel of God had been made known.

B. Paul's Revelation of the Mystery (1:26)

1. It was hidden from ages and generations

"The mystery which has been hidden from the past ages and generations." A biblical "mystery" is not a puzzle to be solved by clever people. It is a truth that could not be known

until God revealed it. In the parallel passage, Ephesians 3, Paul tells us where this mystery was hidden:

> *“and to bring to light what is the administration of the mystery which for ages has been hidden in God who created all things;”*
>
> — Ephesians 3:9 (NASB95)

In the dispensational understanding followed in this study, the Church was not revealed in the Old Testament. It was future even in the Gospels, where Jesus said, "I will build My church" (Matt. 16:18). One enters the Church, the body of Christ, by Spirit baptism: "For by one Spirit we were all baptized into one body" (1 Cor. 12:13). That first occurred at Pentecost (Acts 2:1–4; 11:15–16), which is when the Church began.

We should also be clear about what the mystery is not. It is not simply that Gentiles would be saved. As early as Genesis 12:3 God promised that all the families of the earth would be blessed through Abraham's seed. The mystery is that Jew and Gentile would be joined in one body, on the same level, where "there is neither Jew nor Greek" (Gal. 3:28; Eph. 3:6). In Paul's letters at least four mysteries concern the Church:

- Jew and Gentile in one body (Eph. 3:3–6).
- The indwelling Christ (Col. 1:26–27).
- The Church as the bride of Christ (Eph. 5:32).
- The rapture of the Church (1 Cor. 15:51–52).

2. It is now manifested to His saints

"But has now been manifested to His saints." Paul was the primary recipient of this revelation. Peter accepted what Paul preached, though they had some serious conversations along the way (Gal. 2). Peter even admitted that Paul wrote some things that are hard to understand:

> *“and regard the patience of our Lord as salvation; just as also our beloved brother Paul, according to the wisdom given him, wrote to you, as also in all his letters, speaking in them of these things, in which are some things hard to understand, which the untaught and unstable distort, as they do also the rest of the Scriptures, to their own destruction.”*
>
> — 2 Peter 3:15–16 (NASB95)

III. The Secret of the Mystery (1:27)

A. God Willed to Reveal It

"To whom God willed to make known what is the riches of the glory of this mystery." God's revelation is progressive. Each dispensation receives sufficient revelation to live a life that honors God. Through Paul, and through the other apostles and prophets, God gave the revelation for the Church age, the body of truth we now hold in the New Testament.

B. The Gentiles Received It

"Among the Gentiles." Paul emphasizes the Gentiles because that was his God-given assignment. He was the apostle to the Gentiles (Rom. 11:13), though it was Peter who first opened the door to them at the house of Cornelius (Acts 10–11). The wonder is that Gentiles, once "excluded from the commonwealth of Israel … having no hope and without God in the world" (Eph. 2:12), now have Christ dwelling in them.

C. "Christ in You" Defines It

"Which is Christ in you, the hope of glory." This is the heart of the mystery. The Messiah does not merely stand beside His people or rule over them from afar; He lives in them. That was something no Old Testament saint experienced in this way.

What is "the hope of glory"? This study understands "glory" here not as simply getting to heaven. Paul is not saying that Christ in you is your hope of eternal life; that was settled when you believed (1:13–14). "The hope of glory" is the confident expectation of sharing in Christ's glory when He is revealed (3:4) and when believers stand before Him at the Judgment Seat (Rom. 8:17–18; 2 Tim. 2:12).

IV. The Success of the Mystery (1:28–29)

A. The Goal: Presenting Every Believer Complete (1:28c)

1. The presentation

"So that we may present every man." This presentation looks ahead to the Judgment Seat of Christ (1 Cor. 3:10–15; 2 Cor. 5:10). We can summarize what Scripture teaches about it:

- It is the evaluation of the works of Church-age believers.
- Only believers will be there.
- The result will be the receiving or the loss of rewards.
- Eternal life is not the issue; it is already the believer's possession.

Those who have allowed the indwelling Christ to lead them into lives and service that please Him will share in His glory in His earthly kingdom for a thousand years (Rev. 20:4–6) and afterward in the eternal kingdom. The only hope of that is Christ in you, and you in Christ.

2. The perfection

"Complete in Christ." The word (*teleios*) does not mean sinless perfection. It means complete, mature, full-grown. Paul's desire, and the desire of every minister of Christ, is to bring believers to maturity and present them to Christ in that day. He did not want them to remain babies (cf. 1 Cor. 3:1–3; Heb. 5:12–14).

B. The Means: Proclaiming Christ (1:28a–b)

"We proclaim Him." Notice that the message is a Person. Paul does not proclaim a system or a set of rules but Christ Himself. Two activities accompany that proclamation.

1. Admonishing

"Admonishing every man." To admonish (*noutheteō*) is to warn, to put sense into the mind. Believers are called sheep, and you cannot drive sheep; you lead them. If you are going to warn, do it wisely, and never forget the aim: to present them mature to the Lord, not to drive them into the arms of false teachers who seem "oh so loving."

2. Teaching

"And teaching every man with all wisdom." Likewise, teaching must be done wisely. Teaching is not just telling. The truth must be told accurately, explained convincingly, and applied lovingly. And notice the repeated "every man." The false teachers had a mature elite; Paul's goal is maturity for every believer.

C. The Method: Laboring in His Power (1:29)

1. Toiling and striving

"For this purpose also I labor, striving." Developing maturity in believers is hard work. The word "labor" (*kopiaō*) means to toil to the point of weariness. "Striving" (*agōnizomai*) is the word from which we get "agonize," the language of the athlete straining in the contest. But Paul does not labor alone.

2. According to His energy

"According to His power, which mightily works within me." Paul uses the language of energy: "according to His working (*energeia*) which works (*energeō*) in me in power." God supplies the energy. What God has called you to do, He will enable you to do. And since the power is His, so is the credit. If any praise is due, the Lord will give it on that day: "Well done, good and faithful slave" (Matt. 25:21).

Conclusion

Paul suffered gladly, served faithfully as a steward, and labored to exhaustion, all to make known one great secret: Christ in you, the hope of glory. The false teachers offered mysteries for the few. God has revealed His mystery to all His saints, and it is the indwelling Christ.

Every believer has Christ living within. The question is whether we will let Him lead us to maturity, so that on the day of presentation we will be found complete in Him and share in His glory.

Lord, thank You.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Grammar and parsing: Blue Letter Bible. Sources cited selectively: STR (Strong's), THAY (Thayer's), ATR (A. T. Robertson), VINE (Vine's), MRV (Vincent's), LXX (Septuagint usage).

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
v.24	**πάθημα** *sufferings*	**G3804** *pathēma* Dat. Neut. Pl.	**STR:** something undergone, hardship, pain. **Significance:** Paul rejoices in what he suffers as service for the Church.
v.24	**ἀνταναπληρόω** *fill up*	**G466** *antanaplēroō* Pres. Act. Ind. 1st Sg.	**ATR:** a double compound found only here; "to fill up in turn," on one's part. **Significance:** Paul takes his turn in the afflictions the Church bears for Christ's sake.
v.24	**θλῖψις** *afflictions*	**G2347** *thlipsis* Gen. Fem. Pl.	**THAY:** pressure, distress from outward circumstances. **VINE:** never used in the NT of Christ's atoning sufferings. **Significance:** The "lack" is not in the atonement but in the trials still to be borne by His body.
v.25	**οἰκονομία** *stewardship*	**G3622** *oikonomia* Acc. Fem. Sg.	**VINE:** management of a household; a trust or administration. **Significance:** Paul dispenses what God entrusted to him; he does not own the message.
v.26	**μυστήριον** *mystery*	**G3466** *mystērion* Nom. Neut. Sg.	**VINE:** in the NT, truth that cannot be known except by divine revelation, now made known. **Significance:** Not a secret for an elite but truth revealed to all the saints.
v.26	**ἀποκρύπτω** *hidden*	**G613** *apokryptō* Perf. Pass. Ptc. Nom. Neut. Sg.	**ATR:** perfect: it had remained hidden through the ages. **Significance:** The mystery was hidden in God (Eph. 3:9) until revealed.
v.26	**φανερόω** *manifested*	**G5319** *phaneroō* Aor. Pass. Ind. 3rd Sg.	**STR:** to make visible, make known. **Significance:** What was hidden is now openly revealed to His saints.
v.27	**πλοῦτος** *riches*	**G4149** *ploutos* Nom. Neut. Sg.	**THAY:** wealth, abundance. **Significance:** The mystery is wealth beyond measure: Christ Himself in believers.
v.27	**δόξα** *glory*	**G1391** *doxa* Gen. Fem. Sg.	**LXX:** translates Hebrew *kavod*, weight, splendor. **Significance:** The hope of sharing Christ's glory when He is revealed (3:4).
v.28	**νουθετέω** *admonishing*	**G3560** *noutheteō* Pres. Act. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Pl.	**THAY:** to put in mind, warn, exhort. **Significance:** Loving warning that leads sheep rather than driving them.

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
v.28	**τέλειος** *complete*	**G5046** *teleios* Acc. Masc. Sg.	**VINE:** having reached its end; full-grown, mature. **Significance:** Not sinless perfection but maturity in Christ for every believer.
v.29	**κοπιάω** *labor*	**G2872** *kopiaō* Pres. Act. Ind. 1st Sg.	**MRV:** to toil to the point of weariness. **Significance:** Ministry toward maturity is hard, wearying work.
v.29	**ἀγωνίζομαι** *striving*	**G75** *agōnizomai* Pres. Mid. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Sg.	**VINE:** to contend in the games; to struggle, agonize. **Significance:** Paul strains like an athlete, yet in Christ's power (cf. 2:1; 4:12).
v.29	**ἐνέργεια** *power, working*	**G1753** *energeia* Acc. Fem. Sg.	**THAY:** working, efficiency; used only of superhuman power in the NT. **Significance:** God supplies the energy that "energizes" (*energeō*) His servants.

Grammar key — Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. Verb Mood: Ind. · Imp. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Review prompt	From the commentary
Why is Christ's atonement not "lacking"?	Jesus said "It is finished"; the word *thlipsis* refers to life's afflictions, not atoning suffering.
What is a biblical "mystery"?	Truth that could not be known until God revealed it; now made known to His saints.
What is the mystery not, and what is it?	Not Gentile salvation (Gen. 12:3) but Jew and Gentile in one body, and Christ in you.
Name the four Church mysteries listed.	One body (Eph. 3); indwelling Christ (Col. 1); bride (Eph. 5); rapture (1 Cor. 15).
What two activities accompany proclaiming Christ?	Admonishing (warning) and teaching, both "with all wisdom."

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. How can Paul speak of "filling up what is lacking in Christ's afflictions" without denying the finished work of the cross?

> **Leader's answer:** The word *thlipsis* is never used of Christ's atoning death; it refers to outward distress. Christ's atonement is complete (John 19:30; Heb. 10:14). What remains is the share of

affliction His body bears in serving Him, and the Head feels the body's suffering (Acts 9:4).

2. What does "stewardship" teach about Paul's view of his ministry?

Leader's answer: A steward manages what belongs to his master. Paul did not invent or own his message; he faithfully dispensed what God entrusted to him "for your benefit," fully carrying out the preaching of the Word.

3. According to this study, what does "the hope of glory" refer to, and why does that matter?

Leader's answer: Not the hope of reaching heaven, which is settled at faith, but the expectation of sharing Christ's glory when He is revealed and believers are evaluated at the Judgment Seat. It keeps assurance secure while keeping the motive for faithful living strong.

4. Why does Paul repeat "every man" three times in verse 28?

Leader's answer: The false teaching was elitist, offering maturity to a select few. Paul's ministry aims at every believer: warning every one, teaching every one, presenting every one complete in Christ.

5. What does verse 29 teach about the balance between hard work and dependence on God?

Leader's answer: Paul toiled to exhaustion and strained like an athlete, yet he did so "according to His power." Ministry demands full effort, but the energy comes from Christ, and so does the credit.

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verses	Theme	Key truth
1:24	The suffering	Paul rejoices to bear afflictions for the sake of Christ's body, the Church.
1:25–26	The stewardship	As God's steward, Paul makes known the mystery hidden for ages and now revealed.
1:27	The secret	The mystery's riches: Christ in you, the hope of glory, even among Gentiles.
1:28–29	The success	Proclaiming Christ, warning and teaching, Paul labors in Christ's power to present every believer mature.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · personal and corporate

1. Live Aware of the Indwelling Christ

Scripture anchor: Colossians 1:27

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, III.C, and ② Devotional

Christ lives in every believer. That truth is meant to shape ordinary moments: the conversation at work, the temptation at night, the fear in the waiting room. We are never alone, and we never lack the resources of the One who holds all things together.

Reflection: In what situation this week did you act as though Christ were not living in you?

Practical step: Set a reminder three times a day this week with the words "Christ in you" and pause to thank Him for His presence.

2. Count Hardship as Service

Scripture anchor: Colossians 1:24

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, I

Paul rejoiced in sufferings because they served the Church. Not every trial is persecution, but every trial faced faithfully can strengthen other believers who watch how we endure. Our suffering is never wasted when it is offered to the Head for the good of the body.

Reflection: Who is watching how you handle your current hardship?

Practical step: Share with one believer this week how God is helping you through a difficulty.

3. Invest in Someone's Maturity

Scripture anchor: Colossians 1:28–29

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, IV; cf. Hendricks, As Iron Sharpens Iron (FGR)

Paul labored to present every believer mature. Howard Hendricks spent a lifetime urging believers to have a "Paul" who mentors them and a "Timothy" whom they mentor. You do not need a pulpit to warn and teach with wisdom; you need a relationship and a Bible.

Reflection: Who is a younger believer you could help grow?

Practical step: Invite one believer to read Colossians with you over the coming weeks.

End of Study · Colossians 1:24–29